

Skills Summary

Interior and Exterior Polygon Angle Sums

Use this reference while completing your worksheet or when studying.

Skill 1 — Interior angle sum of a convex polygon

Theorem: For a convex polygon with n sides, sum of interior angles = $(n - 2) 180^\circ$.

- *Why:* diagonals from one vertex cut the polygon into exactly $n - 2$ triangles, and each triangle holds 180° .
- Running it backwards finds n : set $(n - 2)180$ equal to the given sum.
- If one angle is missing, add the known angles and subtract from the sum.

Example: Find the interior angle sum of a convex heptagon.

Step 1. Only the number of sides is known and a total is wanted, so this is the interior angle sum theorem, not the exterior one.

Step 2. $n = 7$, so the sum is $(7 - 2)180^\circ = 5 \cdot 180^\circ \Rightarrow 900^\circ$

Try it: Three angles of a convex quadrilateral are 88° , 154° , and 97° . Find the fourth, x .

check: $x = 88^\circ$

Skill 2 — Exterior angles always total 360 degrees

Theorem: Taking one exterior angle at each vertex, sum of exterior angles = 360° — for every convex polygon, whatever n is.

- At each vertex the interior and exterior angles form a linear pair: interior + exterior = 180° .
- Regular polygon: one exterior angle = $\frac{360^\circ}{n}$, so $n = \frac{360^\circ}{\text{one exterior angle}}$.

Example: Find one exterior angle of a regular nonagon.

Step 1. The polygon is regular and an exterior angle is wanted, so share the fixed 360° total equally among the vertices.

Step 2. $n = 9$, so one exterior angle is $360^\circ \div 9 \Rightarrow 40^\circ$

Try it: Each exterior angle of a regular polygon is 45° . How many sides has it?

check: $n = 8$

Skill 3 — Angles of a regular polygon

Formulas: In a *regular* n -gon all angles are congruent, so

$$\text{one interior angle} = \frac{(n-2)180^\circ}{n}, \quad \text{one exterior angle} = \frac{360^\circ}{n}.$$

The two are supplementary, so either one gives the other instantly.

Example: Find one interior angle of a regular pentagon.

Step 1. Regular means the interior total is shared equally, so divide the interior angle sum by the number of angles.

Step 2. $\frac{(5-2)180^\circ}{5} = \frac{540^\circ}{5} \Rightarrow 108^\circ$

Try it: Each interior angle of a regular polygon is 140° . How many sides has it?

6 = n :check

(!) Watch out: The 360° belongs to the *exterior* angles only. Dividing 360° by n gives an exterior angle, never an interior one — and $(n-2)180^\circ$ is a total for the whole polygon, not a single angle.